

The modern Middle East

With the discovery of vast oil fields in the early 20th century, the Middle East went through a period of rapid development and modernization. Small villages and settlements, home to nomadic Bedouin populations, grew into huge cities connected by fast highways. Today, 10 of the Middle East's countries—Iran, Iraq, Syria, Kuwait, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Qatar, United Arab Emirates (UAE), Oman, and Yemen—have 48 percent of the world's known oil reserves. The tremendous wealth brought by the oil industry has led to improved living conditions for many people. However, the region still faces huge problems—the long history of conflict (see p.201) is ongoing, and human rights abuses on issues such as freedom of speech and the treatment of women affect the region's standing on the world stage.

MODERN MEGACITIES

Over the years, the city of Dubai has transformed from a small trading center into a major international city with thousands of towering skyscrapers dotting the skyline. It is home to modern architectural marvels, such as the Burj Khalifa, the tallest building in the world, and the twisting Cayan Tower (right).



▲ IRRIGATION CANALS

Much of the Middle East is made up of desert, and the region does not get a lot of rainfall. Fresh water for farming is pumped up from underground water reserves and transported through stone or brick irrigation canals, such as this one in Saudi Arabia.

